draw.io User Guide

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Chapter 1. Copyright statement

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Chapter 2. Introduction

About draw.io

draw.io (also known as diagrams.net) in a diagramming tool. It is available as a web application and a desktop application, and through integrations with supported platforms. You can use it to create, edit and share a variety of diagrams including:

- Business process diagrams
- Flowcharts
- Organisation charts
- Architectural diagrams and layouts
- Unified Modeling Language (UML) diagrams
- Entity-Relationship (ER) diagrams
- Database schemas
- Business Process Model and Notation (BPMN) diagrams
- Circuit diagrams

About This Guide

This user guide describes how to use the draw.io (version 32.2.0) in a web browser on desktop and laptop computers. It covers the features and workflows available through a web browser.

Intended Audience

If you are a business analyst, project manager, IT professional, technical writer, student, educator, or anyone with little to no experience creating diagrams, you’re in the right place.

This user guide covers the basics of using draw.io to create, edit, format, save, and export diagrams.

Follow the step-by-step instructions to get started, or jump to the section you need.

Chapter 3. Open draw.io

Ensure you have an internet connection and a supported web browser.

To get started, open the draw.io in the browser.

To open draw.io:

1. Open a web browser.
2. In the address bar, enter https://app.diagrams.net/.
3. On your keyboard, press **Enter**.

The draw.io editor opens with a blank canvas.

Chapter 4. Understanding the draw.io editor

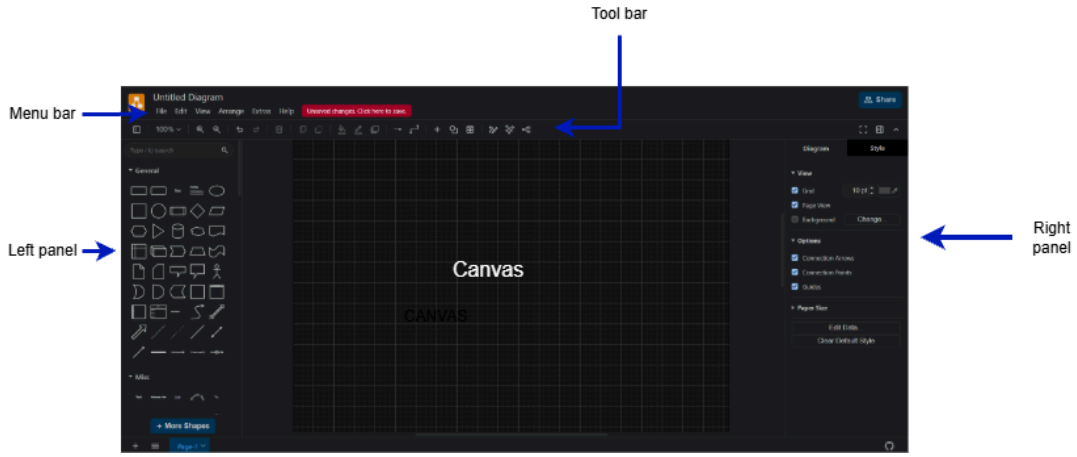


Figure 1. Figure: draw.io editor

The draw.io editor consists of the following areas:

- **Menu bar**. Provides access to file management commands, such as File and Edit, and editor commands, such as View, Arrange, Extras, and Help.
- **Toolbar**. Provides quick access to commonly used commands, such as Zoom, Undo, Redo, Delete, Fill Color, and Connection.
- **Left panel**. Provides shapes and other diagram elements that you can add to the canvas, such as circles, squares, diamonds, curves, and callouts.
- **Canvas**. Provides the workspace where you create and edit diagrams.
- **Right panel**. Provides options for managing the canvas view and formatting diagram elements, including grid and page settings and shape formatting.

Chapter 5. Select a template

Templates are predesigned diagrams that provide a starting layout for different types of diagrams. draw.io provides a variety of templates. You can also select a blank diagram to create a diagram from scratch.

When you select a template, you can enter a name for the diagram. The diagram is saved in the draw.io XML format by default. This is the editable format that you can use to continue editing the diagram in draw.io.

To select a template:

1. On the draw.io editor, click **File** in the upper-left corner.
2. From the menu, select **New**.
3. In the dialog box, do one of the following:
    - To create a diagram from scratch, click **Blank Diagram**.
    - To use a template, select the required template. For example, select Flowchart.
4. Next to **Diagram Name**, enter the name of the diagram.

The draw.io editor opens with the selected template. If you entered a diagram name, the name appears in the upper-left corner of the canvas.

Chapter 6. Select shapes for a diagram

Shapes are graphical elements that you can add to a diagram to represent objects, processes, or other information. Whether you are working with a template or a blank canvas, you can add shapes to your diagram.

draw.io provides a variety of shapes, including basic shapes such as Square, Rectangle, and Circles, as well as more specialized shapes such as Callouts, 8 Point Stars, and Polylines.

To add a shape:

1. In the left panel, if the shape category that contains the shape isn't expanded, click the category name. For example: General.
2. Click the required shape.
3. Repeat steps 1 and 2 to add more shapes.

The selected shapes are added to the canvas.

Chapter 7. Add text to shapes and connectors

You can add text to shapes and connectors to identify categories, segments, systems, the flow of information, or other elements in a diagram.

To add text to shapes and connectors:

1. On the canvas, click the shape or connector to which you want to add text.
2. Enter the text.

Chapter 8. Connect shapes

After adding shapes to the canvas, connect them to show the relationship or flow between them. After you add shapes to the canvas, connect them to show the relationship or flow between them. You can connect shapes that are already on the canvas, or add a new shape and connect it to an existing one. In both cases, you use the blue directional arrows that appear when you point to a shape.

- To connect existing shapes see, Connect existing shapes *(on page 10)*.
- To connect a new shape, see Connect a new shape *(on page 10)*.

Connect existing shapes

To connect existing shapes:

1. On the canvas, point to one of the shapes that you want to connect. Four blue directional arrows appear around the shape.
2. Click the arrow that points toward the other shape.

A connector appears between the two shapes.

Connect a new shape

To add and connect a new shape:

1. On the canvas, hover over the shape to which you want to add a new shape.
2. Hover over the arrow in the direction in which you want to add the new shape.
3. Select the required shape from the available options.

The new shape is added to the canvas and connected to the selected shape.

Chapter 9. Move a shape

You can move a shape on the canvas to change its position within the diagram.

To move a shape:

- On the canvas, select and drag the required shape to the desired location.

The shape moves to the new location. Any connectors attached to the shape stay connected.

Chapter 10. Resize a shape

You can resize a shape to make it larger or smaller in the diagram.

To resize a shape:

1. On the canvas, select the shape that you want to resize.
2. Drag a sizing handle outward to enlarge the shape or inward to reduce the shape.

The shape becomes larger or smaller, depending on the direction that you drag the handle.

Chapter 11. Format shapes

You can format shapes to change their appearance and make the diagram easier to read.

To format a shape:

1. On the canvas, select the shape that you want to format.
2. In the right panel, click the **Style** tab.
3. If required, change the shape's fill color, line color, or line style.
4. If required, click the **Text** tab to change the font, text size, alignment, or text color.
5. If required, click the **Arrange** tab to change the shape's position, size, or rotation.
6. Repeat steps 1-5 for other shapes as needed.

The changes appear on the shape as you make them.

Chapter 12. Duplicating objects

Duplicating creates a copy of the shapes and connectors that you select, with the same size and formatting, so you can reuse them without redrawing.

To duplicate a shape or connector:

1. On the canvas, click the shape or connector that you want to duplicate. .
2. Press Ctrl+D (Windows) or Command+D (macOS)..

A copy of the selected shapes or connectors appears on the canvas. Drag the copy to the position that you want.

Chapter 13. Align shapes

To perform this task, you must select at least two shapes on the canvas.

Alignment is used to line up two or more selected objects relative to one another.

The following table lists the alignment options available in draw.io.:

Option	Aligns the selected objects with the
Left Align	left edge of the leftmost selected object.
Center	horizontal center of the selection
Right Align	top edge of the right edge of the rightmost shape.
Top Align	bottom edge of the top edge of the uppermost shape.
Middle	with the vertical center of the selection.
Bottom Align	bottom edge of the lowest shape.

To align shapes:

1. On the canvas, select the shapes that you want to align.
2. On the menu bar, click **Arrange**.
3. On the **Arrange** menu, click the alignment option that you want.

The selected shapes align according to the option that you chose.

Chapter 14. Arrange overlapping objects

When objects overlap, you can change their order to control which objects appear in front of or behind other objects.

The arrangement options are

Arrangement	**Moves the selected object**
To Front	to the front of all other objects.
To Back	to the back of all other objects.
Bring Forward	one level forward in the stacking order.
Send Backward	one level backward in the stacking order.

To arrange objects:

1. On the canvas, select the required object.
2. On the menu bar, click **Arrange**.
3. From the submenu, select the required arrangement type. For example: **To Back**.

Chapter 15. Save a diagram

You can save a diagram at any point while creating it. When you save a diagram, draw.io stores it in the selected location. You can save a diagram using Save or Save As. The option you use depends on whether you want to save changes to an existing diagram or save a diagram as a new file.

- **Save:**Use this option to save changes to a diagram that has already been saved. For instructions, see Save changes to a diagram *(on page 17)*.
- **Save as:** Use this option to save a new diagram or save an existing diagram with a different file name or location. For instructions, see Save a new diagram *(on page 17)*.

When saving a diagram, you can select a supported online storage service or your local computer as the storage location, depending on the options available in your draw.io environment. This section covers the process of saving the file in the local system.

The XML (.drawio) format is selected by default when saving a diagram as a draw.io file. If you want to continue making changes to the diagram, save in this format.

Save changes to a diagram

To save changes to an existing diagram:

1. On the draw.io editor, click **File**.
2. Click**Save**.

The selected location stores the diagram with the changes.

Save a new diagram

To save a new diagram or save an existing diagram with a different name or location:

1. On the draw.io editor, click **File**.
2. On the menu, click **Save as**.
3. In the dialog box that appears, enter the file name.
4. Select the required storage location.
5. Click**Save**.

The selected location stores new diagram with the changes.

Chapter 16. Export a diagram

When you export a file in draw.io, it is saved as a non-editable format. You can use this format when you want to share, publish, embed, or use the diagram elsewhere.

To export a file:

1. On the draw.io editor, click **File**.
2. On the menu, click **Export as**.
3. On the submenu, click the format you want to export the file in.
4. In the **Image** dialog box, make the necessary changes.
5. Click **Export**.
6. In the dialog box that appears, do the following:
    a. Next to Save as, enter the file name.
    b. Next to Where, click the dropdown to select the location to want the file to be exported in.

The exported file is saved in the provided location.

Chapter 17. Frequently Asked Questions

This section answers frequently asked questions about using draw.io. It covers common questions about creating, editing, saving, and exporting diagrams.

Q. Why isn't the connector connecting to a shape?

- This can happen when you are connecting two different shapes. When dragging the connector endpoint to the target shape, continue dragging until a connection point on the target shape is highlighted. Move the endpoint to the required connection point and release the connector.

Q. How do I bring an object in front of another object?

- If two objects overlap and you want to move one in front of the other, select the object and choose Arrange > To Front.

  For more information, see Arrange overlapping objects *(on page 16)*.

Q. Why aren't my objects aligned?

- Select at least two objects before selecting Arrange > Align. Alignment does not work when only one object is selected.

  For more information, see Align shapes *(on page 15)*.

Q. Why is my exported diagram difficult to read?

- The text or objects in the exported diagram may be difficult to read if the export settings are not suitable for the diagram. Review the export settings and adjust them as needed before exporting the diagram again. To learn more, see Export a diagram *(on page 18)*.

Chapter 18. Reference

The official draw.io documentation was consulted as a reference during the preparation of this guide.

- draw.io documentation: https://www.drawio.com/docs/